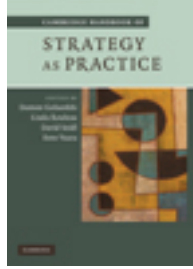


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Cambridge Handbook of Strategy as Practice

Edited by Damon Golsorkhi, Linda Rouleau, David Seidl, Eero Vaara

Book DOI: <http://dx.doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511777882>

Online ISBN: 9780511777882

Hardback ISBN: 9780521517287

Paperback ISBN: 9781107404007

Chapter

8 - An activity-theory approach to Strategy as Practice pp. 127-140

Chapter DOI: <http://dx.doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511777882.009>

Cambridge University Press

An activity-theory approach to Strategy as Practice

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An activity-theory approach to Strategy as Practice

This chapter introduces activity theory as an approach for studying Strategy as Practice. Activity theory conceptualizes the ongoing construction of activity as a product of activity systems, comprising the actor, the community with which that actor interacts and those symbolic and material tools that mediate between actors, their community and their pursuit of activity. Activity theory has its roots in Russian social psychology. Russian cultural historical activity theory, as developed by Vygotsky (1978), initially conceptualized early childhood development through children's interaction in activities with their community. His followers, particularly Leontiev (1978), developed this theory more widely to encompass the interaction between the individual and the collective in the pursuit of activity. Activity theory has been widely adopted within the fields of education and human-computer interaction (Kaptelinin and Nardi 2006), as well as being developed in a particular way by Engeström (1990) for examining work practices in a range of contexts. More recently it has been used within organization theory to examine organizational and strategy practice (e.g. Blackler 1993, 1995; Blackler *et al.* 2000; Groleau 2006; Jarzabkowski 2003, 2005). Activity theory provides a resource for analysing the interaction between practitioners, practices and praxis through the study of activity systems.

In this chapter, I shall explain some specific concepts associated with activity theory and indicate its value for studying Strategy as Practice as it is socially accomplished by individuals in interaction with their wider social group and the artefacts of interaction. In particular, the activity theory's focus on actors as social individuals is explained as a conceptual basis for studying the core question in

Strategy as Practice research; what strategy practitioners *do*. The structure of the chapter is in four parts. First, activity theory is introduced through an overview of its historical background and application in different fields. Second, an activity system conceptual framework is developed. Third, the elements of the activity system are explained in more detail and explicitly linked to each of the core Strategy as Practice concepts, practitioners, practices and praxis. In doing so, links are made to existing Strategy as Practice research and brief empirical examples are provided of Strategy as Practice topics that might be addressed using activity theory. Fourth, the chapter concludes with a brief comparison of the theoretical resources provided by activity theory and some other potential theories of practice. Throughout the chapter, a number of key authors who have founded and developed activity theory or used it in various disciplinary fields are introduced, which may also offer valuable resources and further reading for those wishing to make greater use of activity theory.

Background to activity theory

In this section I provide a brief overview of the foundations of activity theory before discussing some specific elements of this complex theory which are particularly applicable to the Strategy as Practice agenda. Activity theory was initially developed by Russian social psychologist, Vygotsky, in the era following the Russian revolution. Vygotsky (1978) was concerned with the development of human consciousness. In particular, he wanted to avoid representations of the mind as separate from the social context in which consciousness develops. Hence, he derived a theory that accounted for human consciousness as it develops in interaction

with a collectively evolving cultural and historical context. His theory of the individual and of human cognition is thus inherently social. Vygotsky's students and colleagues, particularly Leontiev (1978), further developed this theory by proposing that the unit of analysis in which to examine human consciousness was activity. In activity, individuals interact with the wider cultural and historical context in which they are engaged, so developing consciousness in an overtly social way that is both conditioned by and responsive to the wider collective of which they are part. While individuals are shaped by the collective with which they interact, this is not deterministic, as individuals both learn how to act from and also contribute to the evolving cultural and historical context.

Activity theory thus premises that psychological development is a social process arising from an individual's interactions within particular historical and cultural contexts (Vygotsky 1978). Interaction provides an interpretative basis from which individuals attribute meaning to their own and others' actions (Vygotsky 1978; Wertsch 1985). This interaction is profoundly located within practical activity, being the daily work in which actors engage (Kozulin 1999; Leontiev 1978). In this activity, we may study *how*, through what means, individuals interact with others and are enabled to partake in the collective activity of a community. In activity theory, practical activity is mediated through the technical and psychological tools that individuals draw upon to interact with each other (Wertsch 1985). Vygotsky (1978) was concerned with psychological tools, such as algebraic symbols, schemes, diagrams, maps and mechanical drawings, as well as the acquisition and use of language, through which actors invoke meaning and which mediate between their own subjective consciousness and the activity they perform in a community. The point of such tools is that they are oriented towards activity. They come into use to mediate the practical activity that is constructed between actors (Kozulin 1999). These concepts of practical activity and mediation will be further explained in following sections of the chapter.

While Vygotsky and his colleagues developed many of the basic premises in activity theory, the theory has been elaborated as it was adopted

in adjacent fields of study. Activity theory has been drawn on in the field of human and computer interaction in two ways. First, activity theory underpins much of the literature on the situated interactions between technology and humans (e.g. Kaptelinin and Nardi 2006; Nardi 1996). Second, the distributed and parallel processing functions of computing systems, particularly as they enable collaborative working, have been analysed using activity theory concepts of cognition as social activity that is distributed across multiple actors in interaction. Thus activity theory has been used to aid the design of technologies to better account for the human operator's activity, as well as to understand how distributed technological systems work in human situations (e.g. Frawley 1997). Activity theory is particularly helpful for understanding how technologies mediate human interactions in distributed systems (e.g. Rabardel and Beguin 2005). For example, activity theory analyses contribute to knowledge about the subjective experiences of actors using a technology and also how that technology mediates their interaction with others who may be distributed across time and space (e.g. virtual communities or parallel processing) and how it enables or constrains their collective activity (Omicini and Ossowski, 2004; Walker 2004). These aspects of activity theory have also informed a vein of work on distributed cognition (e.g. Hutchins 1995) that has, in its turn, informed practice-based studies of coordination and collaboration in organizations (e.g. Orlikowski 2002).

As a theory of social and cognitive development, activity theory has also been drawn upon in psychology-related fields such as education. It informs Lave and Wenger's (1991) theory of learning, which illustrates the way that newcomers learn through participation how to construct themselves as members of a community, even as their participation reconstructs that community. Engeström (1987 1990) has been a key figure in the development of activity theory within the education and learning field, as well as taking it more widely into the study of organizations. One of Engeström's main contributions has been defining the unit of analysis as the activity system, so shifting the analytic focus from individual activity to the whole activity system in which an activity occurs (see Kaptelinin and Nardi

2006, pp. 137–143). The activity system concept provides an integrative framework, encompassing the interactions that take place between individuals, the cultural and historical context of their activity, and the various tools and technologies that mediate that activity. Engeström's (1993) approach elaborates activity theory by identifying specific elements of the activity system, such as the social structuring mechanisms of role, division of labour, tools, and implicit and explicit rules through which individuals interact as they construct activity.

While Kaptelinin and Nardi (2006) critique Engeström's activity system approach for shifting the focus of activity theory from individual activity to collective activity, this approach has been found useful in organization studies, where there is often an interest in studying how individuals coordinate their actions within the collective activity of a group, unit, division or organization. For example, aspects of Engeström's activity system model have been used by those organization theory scholars who examine organizational learning, contradictions and paradoxes associated with organizational and strategic change (e.g. Adler 2005; Blackler 1993, 1995; Jarzabkowski 2003, 2005; Jarzabkowski and Balogun 2009; Prekter 2006). While an activity system approach does focus attention on the activity arising from the system, it need not exclude individual activity (e.g. Malopinsky 2008) but rather is a matter of foreground and background. That is, a focus on the individual is always sensitive to the collective practices and social interactions of the system in which the individual acts. The activity system approach is particularly apposite to the study of Strategy as Practice because it enables a study of strategy practitioners that also pays attention to the strategy practices that they draw upon and the strategy praxis in which they are engaged.

An activity system framework for studying practitioners, practices and praxis

Before discussing the various concepts of activity theory that can inform Strategy as Practice, I will present an activity system model that draws these concepts together. Figure 8.1 represents the

elements of the activity system explained in this chapter. Other diagrammatic representations of activity systems, which model similar concepts but also interpret some different elements may be found in other studies (e.g. Blackler *et al.* 2000; Engeström 1993; Kaptelinin and Nardi 2006). For the purposes of this chapter, Figure 8.1 introduces those aspects of activity theory that can illuminate the interrelated study of strategy practitioners, strategy praxis and strategy practices.

The subject is the individual or group of actors who form the focal point for analysis. Any group of actors might be positioned as the subject, depending upon whether their contributions to activity are central to the research. In Figure 8.1 (A), strategy practitioners are conceptualized as the subject, those actors who do strategy and through whose eyes Strategy as Practice researchers wish to understand and interpret strategy. Activity theory does not predispose any particular actor to be a strategy practitioner, but rather provides a way of analysing activity from the perspective of an actor that has been designated as a strategy practitioner in any particular study. For example, strategy practitioner subjects have variously been identified as strategy development groups (Blackler *et al.* 1999, 2000), top managers (Jarzabkowski 2003, 2005), and different middle and top managers (Jarzabkowski and Balogun 2009). The subject nature of the practitioner is important, as it emphasizes the Strategy as Practice concern to understand strategy work by analysing the way that a particular actor or group of actors do that work. However, activity theory avoids the reductionism and marginalization of the social that can arise from an excessive focus on the individual (Dawe 1970; Lockwood 1964; Archer 1982). The subject's 'doing' of strategy is always understood in relation to the collective (Figure 8.1, B), comprising those other actors with whom they interact in the pursuit of goal-directed activity.

In activity theory, activity is both goal-oriented, in that it is directed towards a practical outcome (Kozulin 1999) and also shared (Leontiev 1978). Different subjects input their individual actions into the ongoing activity of the activity system. Subjects (Figure 8.1, A) thus associate with a collective (Figure 8.1, B) in constructing goal-oriented activity (Figure 8.1, C). Activity is a

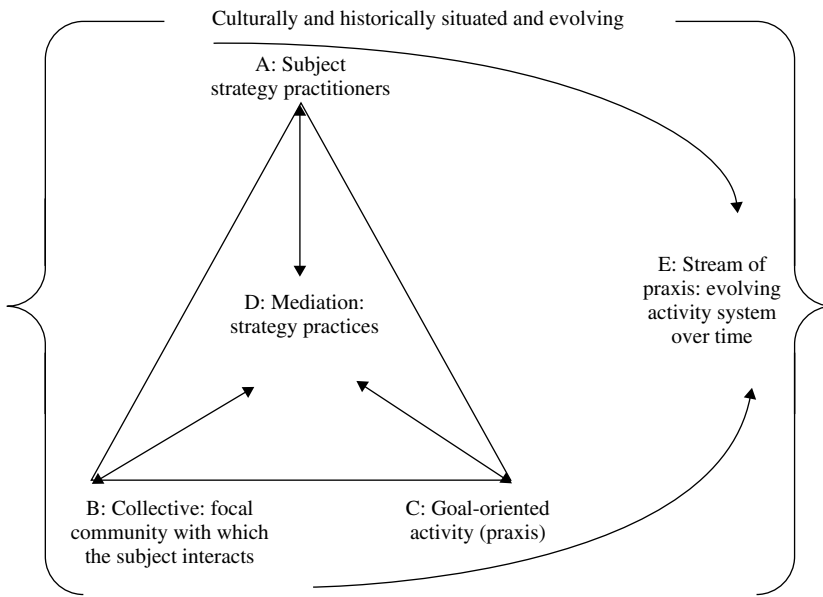


Figure 8.1 An activity framework for studying Strategy as Practice questions

long-duration concept; a flow of activity over time (Figure 8.1, E), as indicated by the curved arrows in Figure 8.1, which imply that the system is not static but is in a constant state of becoming. While activity may be studied at any point in time, it is continuously being constructed in and also constructing the interactions between subjects and their community. Hence, activity is best thought of in dynamic terms as a stream or a flow of activity. In this chapter, I propose that this concept of continuously flowing, goal-oriented activity is valuable for understanding strategy praxis and how it evolves over time. In particular, activity is a useful level of analysis because it separates the tightly interwoven interactions between actors and their community, directing attention to the strategy praxis that is accomplished in these interactions (see also Blackler 1993; Jarzabkowski 2005).

As illustrated in Figure 8.1 (D), an activity system framework also explains the mediation of interactions between subjects, the collective and their shared activity. Mediation is a distinctive concept in activity theory that explains how individual actors, the community and their shared endeavours are integrated in the pursuit of activity. Mediation occurs through various practices, such as strategy

artefacts (e.g. spreadsheets, PowerPoint, whiteboards), strategy processes (e.g. planning and budgeting processes) and strategy language (e.g. competitive advantage, value creation) that enable interaction between actors and their community (Engeström 1993). Such practices are situated, meaning that they reflect both the cultural and historical properties of the wider society in which they are embedded and also the local interpretations of those practices as artefacts for action. Practices of mediation both lend meaning to and are imbued with meaning by the situation in which they are used. They enable interaction between the participants in the activity system and mediate shifting dynamics of influence in the construction of goal-directed activity. Mediation thus provides a means of understanding how diverse actors' actions are rendered mutually intelligible and collective, to the extent that shared activity can take place (Leontiev 1978; Suchman 1987; Turner 1994).

An activity system is not particular to one type of analytic unit, such as an organization or a group. Rather, it provides a conceptual framework for placing boundaries around the focal subject, collective and activity in any particular set of interactions in order to study their dynamics as a system.

Existing studies have identified whole organizations (Blackler 1993, 1995; Jarzabkowski 2003, 2005; Jarzabkowski and Balogun 2009; Spender 1995), strategy development groups (Blackler *et al.* 2000), virtual learning communities (Walker 2004) and doctor–patient interactions (Engeström 1993) as activity systems. The activity system depicted in Figure 8.1 may thus be used to study Strategy as Practice phenomena and research questions at varying levels (see Jarzabkowski and Spee 2009). Conceptualizing Strategy as Practice within an activity system enables us to generate an interdependent view, understanding how the actions in one part of the system affect actions in another part, with these interdependencies mediated by the practices. As an integrative conceptual framework, activity theory is insightful because of its theoretical premise that the study of one part of an activity system necessarily incorporates other parts of the activity system. The next sections of the chapter locate each element of Figure 8.1 within the theoretical resources provided by activity theory and explain how these resources can inform the study of practitioners, practices and praxis.

Strategy practitioners: a subject in interaction with the collective

Strategy as Practice is focused primarily upon strategy as something that *people do* (Jarzabkowski 2004). Furthermore, the Strategy as Practice research agenda aims to take existing strategy research beyond its dominant focus on top managers by bringing a wide range of actors to centre-stage (Jarzabkowski *et al.* 2007; Johnson *et al.* 2003, 2007; Mantere 2005, 2008; Mantere and Vaara 2008; Whittington 2006). This has led to broad definitions of who might be considered a strategy practitioner: ‘Strategy’s practitioners are defined widely, to include both those directly involved in making strategy – most prominently managers and consultants – and those with indirect influence – the policy-makers, the media, the gurus and the business schools who shape legitimate praxis and practices’ (Jarzabkowski and Whittington 2008). Such broad definitions indicate research methodologies that enable the study and comparison of what different types of strategy

practitioner do. Studying what people do is not only an empirical question but also an ontological question, based on whether individual doing is conceptualized as a solo, primarily cognitive, activity or as an interactive, primarily social, activity (Turner 1994). Activity theory brings three important features to the study of what people do.

First, activity theory conceptualizes individual doing as engaging in activities with a wider social group (Vygotsky 1978), also known as the collective or the community (Engeström 1993; Leontiev 1978). ‘Doing’ as an individual in isolation is not possible. Even when individuals act alone, they do so with consideration of the social group, drawing upon the social practices of that group. As illustrated in Figure 8.1, in activity theory the social nature of doing is captured by conceptualizing the individual as the *subject*. It is through this subject’s intentions and actions that activity may be understood. However, activity is always collective, inasmuch as, even in acting alone, an individual relates to the collective and draws upon the tools and symbols of that collective. For example, when strategy practitioners work alone to develop a spreadsheet or think about strategy in the car while driving home, it is impossible to do these actions without drawing upon collective cultural and historical precepts. Through culturally and historically embedded practices – the strategy language of competitive advantage and barriers to entry, strategy concepts such as growth and market value added, and strategy tools such as planning cycles and spreadsheets – practitioners bring into being their solo strategizing actions. These strategizing actions draw upon and contribute to the cultural and historical practices of the wider social group, even if the spreadsheet or strategy thoughts are constructed in isolation.

Conceptualizing the strategy practitioner as a subject interacting within an activity system (see Figure 8.1) provides a social basis for analysing what strategists do within a particular group, division or organization. That is, it conceptualizes doing as located within a specific context, known as an activity system, in which particular types of doing may be better understood. For example, Jarzabkowski (2005, 2008) found that top managers in three universities were each pursuing

four similar streams of strategic activity; research, teaching, commercial income and size and scope. However, their ways of doing these similar streams of activity varied in accordance with the different cultural and historical practices of the activity systems that comprised the universities. The strategy practitioner is thus always a subject interacting with a wider collective and this situatedness is important in studying what strategists do.

Second, activity theory incorporates intentionality into the subject (Kaptelinin and Nardi 2006). While individuals act by drawing upon and contributing to cultural and historical practices, they are not simply pawns of the collective. Rather, when people act, they have motives and desires that they impute to their own actions. Intention is thus inherent in action, even where such intentions may be latent rather than immediately apparent to the actor. Activity theory instantiates the actor as an intentful agent. Intent is particularly important for understanding what comprises a strategist as a competent practitioner, as it goes beyond what strategists do to how they interpret their doings and their aspirations in doing, whether these are ultimately realized or not. Additionally, intent allows us to examine and compare different actors, consultants, middle managers, top managers, non-executive directors and others as strategy practitioners with different motives and desires, even when they interact with the same collective in pursuing strategy. For example, Blackler *et al.* (2000) studied three different strategy development groups within the same high-tech company, comparing their interactions with the organizational activity system about the same strategy. Different subject groups had varied intentions and attributed different motives to their actions, with tensions emerging from the subjects' varying perspectives on the success of their own actions and the organization's strategic activity. These differences in subject intentions provide a basis for identifying variation in engagement and outcomes for the participants within an activity system, even when they are engaged in the same activity.

Third, an activity theory perspective on the actor as a social subject provides an ontological basis for studying what strategists do; that is, it goes beyond the empirical cataloguing of their actions into a

social analysis of these actions. Studying what strategy practitioners do might well result in a long list of things 'done', such as making a telephone call, writing, typing, talking to an associate, going to a meeting, examining a report, drinking coffee, putting numbers in a spreadsheet and so forth. The amount of time allocated to each of these actions could also be analysed, deriving a categorization of things that strategy practitioners do and for how long. This list will indeed describe what strategy practitioners do but will not be very insightful about doing strategy work or about being a strategist. It will become much more insightful if we know who the focal community is that the practitioner telephones, writes to, talks with, meets, examines a report from, develops a spreadsheet for and why these particular actions are important in this context. Furthermore, we may study variations in the intentions attributed to those same actions when the practitioner interacts with a different focal community, such as shareholders, board members, subordinates, consultants or peers. Simply, it is not enough to know that practitioners prepare spreadsheets as part of what they do but rather to know the purpose of the spreadsheet in this activity system, at whom it is directed and what motivations the strategist attributes to his/her actions. When an activity theory lens is applied, analysing what the strategy practitioner does becomes an ontological question about the social nature of doing. Such analysis allows us to understand how what people do constructs them as strategic actors.

Strategy practices as mediators

The Strategy as Practice research agenda has also expressed a concern with the practices of strategy making (e.g. Jarzabkowski 2003, 2004; Jarzabkowski *et al.* 2007; Whittington 2003, 2006). There is, however, little consistency in the definitions of practices that have been employed by scholars within the Strategy as Practice field (Jarzabkowski and Spee, 2009). This is perhaps not surprising, given the various philosophical and theoretical underpinnings of practices (Schatzki *et al.* 2001). Activity theory provides some valuable concepts for analysing the role of strategy practices in the social

accomplishment of strategy. In particular, as illustrated in Figure 8.1, activity theory may be used to conceptualize strategy practices as mediators within an activity system. They mediate between any given subject group, their focal community and the strategic activity in which the community is engaged. Mediation is an aspect of activity theory that increasingly has been drawn upon to look at problems of coordination and shared activity in organizations and in strategy processes (e.g. Adler 2005; Blackler 1993, 1995, Blackler and McDonald 2000; Blackler *et al.* 2000; Foot 2002; Jarzabkowski 2003, 2005; Jarzabkowski and Balogun 2009; Miettinen and Virkkunen 2005; Spender 1995). In these studies, the organization, or one of its parts, is conceptualized as an activity system in which common activity is accomplished through mediation. This section explains the principles of mediation and how it may be drawn upon to conceptualize and understand the role of strategy practices in doing strategy.

Human actions and interactions are mediated: 'Activity theory casts the relationship between people and tools as one of mediation; tools mediate between people and the world' (Kaptelinin and Nardi 2006, p. 10). Mediating tools or mechanisms can take social, physical and cognitive forms, such as operating procedures, heuristics, scripts, routines and languages (Omicini and Ossowski 2004). Mediation suggests that, despite their potentially different perspectives and interests, actors are able to integrate their actions in the pursuit of shared activity (Engeström 1993; Kozulin 1999). However, activity theory does not conceptualize these mechanisms as primarily the instruments of any particular constituent, such as senior managers. Rather, the same mechanisms may be appropriated by different constituents in order to mediate between their varied purposes and interests (Rabardel and Beguin 2005). Furthermore, mediators are not neutral but have historical and cultural baggage that can both constrain and enable action and interaction. Mediating mechanisms thus incorporate longer duration aspects of interaction between actors, so that mediation is not simply part of the moment, but also is part of the wider collective activity. I shall now explain how the concept of mediation supports analysis of three aspects of strategy practices: their role in socially

accomplishing strategic activity; how practices are themselves altered as part of the evolving activity of the activity system; and how they mediate between different subjects within an activity system.

Mediation is a valuable concept for examining how particular practices that coordinate strategic activity, such as planning procedures and resource allocation mechanisms, shape the evolving strategic activity of an organization (Blackler 1993, 1995; Blackler *et al.* 2000; Jarzabkowski 2005; Jarzabkowski and Balogun 2009; Miettinen and Virkkunen 2005). Classical strategy process studies, such as that of Burgelman (1983, 1996), have shown that such mechanisms may be established by senior managers to guide and control the actions of others in the organization towards specific strategies. However, these mechanisms, far from being the property of senior managers, or indeed having an inherent meaning that exists outside any particular group of actors, may be appropriated by different actors to shape strategy according to their own intentions (Jarzabkowski 2005). Indeed, Burgelman found that Intel's shift from a memory chip company in a failing market to a leading microprocessor company was attributable to the way that middle managers appropriated the resource allocation rule of 'maximize margin-per-wafer' to reallocate manufacturing line capacity. This use of the resource allocation mechanism shifted the company strategy towards microprocessors, even as senior managers continued to invest in memory chips as the core Intel strategy. While the resource allocation rule remained constant over time because of the cultural and historical premises of it as a strategic control mechanism at Intel, the meanings attributed to it and the actions taken by different players as they drew upon it, changed the activity of the organization. Hence, as Jarzabkowski (2005) suggests, strategy practices, such as resource allocation models, do not simply coordinate and control strategic activity but rather mediate between different actors in accomplishing an evolving stream of strategic activity over time.

In accommodating different actors, the mediating mechanism may itself come to adopt new cultural and historical meanings: 'Tools evolve during the development of an activity, and they carry the cultural and social knowledge and experiences

of the people who invented and modified them in order to solve certain problems' (Malopinsky 2008, p. 60). While strategy practices are culturally and historically located, such that they tend to have long duration, the activity theoretic premise is that they are also continually evolving as they are drawn upon and modified to accommodate different actors' positions. For example, Jarzabkowski and Balogun (2009) show how strategic planning templates and associated brand campaigns in a multinational, Brandco, evolved from a uniform campaign designed by top managers to a more flexible campaign that could accommodate the different interests and strategic activities of operating companies in small and large markets. These modifications to the planning procedure arose from efforts by actors in different operating companies to socially accomplish the planning procedure within the situated demands of their own market-places. While strategic planning has a 'general' or cross-contextual character when it is introduced, these institutionalized properties come into tension with the locally situated actions of different subjects (Miettinen and Virkkunen 2005). Thus, different subjects must, from their local perspectives, continuously interact with the planning mechanism, fashioning it to their ends, even as they are fashioned by it: 'Accordingly, the activity-theoretical approach regards retooling, the shared creation of artefacts used as means of reflecting and practical transformation of activity, as a key to changing practices' (Miettinen and Virkkunen 2005, p. 443). Jarzabkowski and Balogun (2009) draw on activity theory to explain how and why strategic planning retained a generalized set of steps that characterized it as a planning mechanism, even as it was modified to account for large and small markets as different subjects.

The study of how strategy practices are modified or retooled may also be used to examine how strategy practices mediate between different actors as subjects within an activity system. While activity theory has commonly underplayed the power dynamics of mediation, Blackler and McDonald (2000) suggest that scholars examine power as an ongoing product and medium of the retooling process, as new ways of relating and new activities emerge around the reactions to and modifications

of the mediating mechanism. Jarzabkowski and Balogun's (2009) study illustrates how the evolution of the planning procedure over time also enabled evolving relationships between the key subjects involved in planning. Actors in the different operating companies evolved from being disengaged with a common multinational strategy to being interdependent subjects comprising strategy formulators (top managers), strategy implementers (actors in small markets) and strategy translators (actors in large markets). These evolving relationships were mediated through the social accomplishment and modification of the planning procedure, until each subject group could understand their own activity in relation to others and to the common strategic activity of Brandco. Much organizational research that draws on activity theory has examined the process of mediation but has paid less attention to its implications for how and why subjects come to accommodate each other in pursuing common activity. The evolution and modification of mediating practices to account for the intentions of different subjects (Malopinsky 2007; Miettinen and Virkkunen 2005) is also associated with the evolution and modification of social relationships and power dynamics between these subjects; the practices mediate between subjects within an activity system, even as they mediate the activity in which the system engages.

This section has explained the concept of mediation as it relates to strategy practices and the way that they shape the evolving strategic activity of an activity system; the relationships between subjects in an activity system; and how activity itself shapes the strategy practices. Much literature in the strategy and organization field has used activity theory to look at mechanisms that coordinate strategic activity, such as planning procedures and administrative systems (e.g. Blackler 1993, 1995; Jarzabkowski 2003, 2005; Jarzabkowski and Balogun 2009). However, activity theory provides a richer repertoire of possibilities for identifying strategy practices, which may take social, physical and cognitive forms (Kozulin 1999; Vygotsky 1978), such as operating procedures, heuristics, scripts, routines and languages (Omicini and Ossowski 2004). Future research that draws upon activity theory could undertake more detailed

examinations of how various strategy practices, such as meetings, spreadsheets, decision rules and even particular forms of speech mediate the interactions between actors in an activity system and how this mediation socially accomplishes an evolving stream of strategic activity.

Strategy praxis: object and collective activity

Praxis refers to the stream of activity in which strategy is accomplished over time, which might be explored at different levels depending upon the specific research focus. For example, praxis might be studied at the institutional level as a particular type of widely diffused activity, such as merger and acquisition behaviour within an industry, or at the micro-level of a particular individual or group of individuals engaged in decision-making activity about a merger or acquisition. Various theoretical and research agenda papers in Strategy as Practice have conceptualized praxis at three different levels, micro, meso and macro (e.g. Jarzabkowski 2004; Jarzabkowski *et al.* 2007; Jarzabkowski and Spee, 2009; Johnson *et al.* 2007; Whittington 2006). Activity theory lends itself well to the study of praxis at different levels through two key concepts, goal-directed and collective activity.

First, activity theory focuses upon practical or goal-directed activity. Practical activity provides a focus for interactions; people interact in order to do something (Kozulin 1999; Leontiev 1978), meaning that their activity is oriented towards an outcome or object. The object is a distinctive concept in activity theory; it refers to the higher order motive or desire at which practical activity is directed (Kaptelinin and Nardi 2006; Engeström and Blackler 2005). It is a more comprehensive concept than an objective, which implies a shorter-term, attainable accomplishment that motivates a specific task. Object is a more visionary concept, which might be thought of as a broad goal-orientation that motivates a stream of practical activity comprising of many smaller actions. For example, a university may have a strategic object of being an elite research institution at which its various actors direct their activity. That activity is made up of a complex of actions, such

as writing papers, submitting grant applications, supervising doctoral students, conducting experiments, running conferences and so forth. Each of these actions has an objective that is important to the goal but is not the goal and, at times, may bear little apparent relationship to the goal. For example, attending a colleague's research seminar or reading a doctoral student's chapter are actions with immediate objectives that are no longer directly related to the goal. Rather, these actions are part of a complex of actions undertaken within the activity system as part of the goal-oriented activity that is directed at the object of becoming an elite research institution.

Second, activity is collective (Leontiev 1978). It is accomplished through the input of multiple actors, each of whom may conceptualize the object somewhat differently. A stream of activity is invested with meaning and purpose through the historically and culturally situated understandings of the different actors who contribute to that activity over time (Jarzabkowski 2005; Spender 1995). In the above example, different subjects' perspectives on and interests in the same object of elite research institution may be similar but not the same. Academics may want international recognition from their peers and their subjective interests can be facilitated by the object of an elite research institution, as opportunities to do top research and attain recognition are enabled by the institutional context. Vice-chancellors or rectors want to run institutions that have access to the best financial and human resources, which is enabled by the object of an elite research institution. Students want to be taught by leading academics and attain degrees that have high status in the labour market, which is enabled by the object of an elite research institution. While all subjects share the same broad object, an elite research institution, the goal-oriented activity of each and their cultural and historical expectations about the object may be quite different and even in contradiction with each other (Jarzabkowski 2005; Jarzabkowski and Sillince 2007). For example, academics may want to publish more papers, while vice-chancellors may want more large research grants and students may want more teaching time with top professors. All of these motives that can be attributed to the object are part

of its collective pursuit, so that the object itself is not stable. Rather, the goal-directedness of activity is continuously being accomplished through the interactions and contests between actors. This is a key feature of activity system analysis; examining how a collective output is accomplished through interactions and contests between actors, which modify both the orientation of the activity and of the actors engaged in it (Engeström and Blackler 2005; Foot 2002).

Collective activity is thus purposive or object-oriented activity accomplished through a complex of actions over time. Object-oriented activity is of long duration, being historically and culturally situated, albeit that it is not immutable and evolves over time as the complex of actions are reproduced and reconstructed according to the motives and desires of different parties. As Engeström and Blackler (2005, p. 310) note: 'objects are constructed by actors as they make sense, name, stabilize, represent and enact foci for their actions and activities. Second, at the same time it would also be a mistake to assume that objects are constructed arbitrarily on the spot; objects have histories and built-in affordances, they resist and "bite back"'. These concepts are valuable for understanding strategy praxis at different levels. For example, it is possible to study the strategic object of an organization and analyse how the objects of different strategy groups reconstruct that organizational object, even as they interpret and contribute to it (e.g. Blackler *et al.* 2000), or how the object of one group of actors, such as top managers, is constructed and reconstructed in response to the evolving organizational object (e.g. Jarzabkowski 2005; Jarzabkowski and Balogun 2009). If an organization is to achieve some collective strategic activity, this will comprise partly given intentions and partly emergent features of each subject's own activities, motives and intents.

Furthermore, activity theory may be used to examine contradictions between objects. While most strategy literature deals with strategy as a single construct, examining how organizations pursue or fail to pursue a single strategy, organizations are complex and likely to be pursuing multiple objects. In activity theory, this complexity arises from the multiple cultural and historical layers in which the organization is embedded, which give rise to

contradictions between objects (Engeström 1987, 1990). For example, Jarzabkowski (2005, 2008) found that universities were pursuing four contradictory strategies, research, teaching, commercial income and size and scope. The conflict between these strategies was different in each university, according to their historical and cultural basis, so that universities with a strong foundation as research institutions had significant contradictions between their research and teaching or research and commercial income strategies, whereas those historically founded on a teaching orientation developed contradictions as they faced new requirements to develop a stream of research activity. Other studies (e.g. Blackler and Regan 2009) show how changes in the institutional environment create conflicts within an object, showing the reorganization within family and child support services during changes in policy. Hence, the activity system is always embedded in multiple and contradictory cultural and historical events that both shape and are shaped by what occurs within the system. However, there have been few studies of contradictions between different objects within an activity system or conflicts within any specific object as it undergoes change. Activity theory offers an opportunity for more complex analysis of the conflicts between strategies in organizations. In particular, it provides opportunities to study strategizing within pluralistic contexts that are beset by complex and contradictory goals, which has become an increasingly relevant area for Strategy as Practice research (e.g. Denis *et al.* 2007; Jarzabkowski and Fenton 2006; Jarzabkowski *et al.* 2009).

While these concepts of object and collective activity have only been used in Strategy as Practice research to look at organization-level strategy praxis, other studies have examined quite micro phenomena, such as the object of a doctor–patient interaction (Engeström 1993). Future Strategy as Practice studies might also adopt these concepts to examine the strategy praxis of more micro-activity systems, such as a particular strategy workshop or meeting. The activity system framework (Figure 8.1) would also be valuable to study strategy praxis at the industry level. For example, strategic alliances could be conceptualized as an object comprising a complex interplay of competitive and collaborative interactions by different state, regulatory and

organizational actors, each of whom have different objects in achieving alliance as an industry standard (e.g. de Rond and Bouchiki 2004; Vaara *et al.* 2004). Importantly, the framework provided in this chapter enables a focus upon strategy as a stream of praxis accomplished over time through the interactions between participants in an activity system. Strategy evolves over time as it is contested and differently interpreted by participants, rather than being a single event or objective to be measured for its returns to one party or at one point in time.

Activity theory in the wider landscape of practice theories

This chapter has presented an activity theory approach to the study of Strategy as Practice. In doing so, it has developed an activity theory framework for analysis and explained how specific activity theory concepts can illuminate existing questions and topics for Strategy as Practice research. Particular attributes of activity theory that contribute to the Strategy as Practice agenda are its understanding of the practitioner as a subject in social interaction with a wider activity system. This social understanding of the practitioner is an important contribution to the Strategy as Practice focus on strategy as what people do. However, as this section of the handbook illustrates, activity theory is not the only theory that conceptualizes the individual as a social actor in interaction with social structures of longer duration than any individual actor. Hence, the chapter concludes by locating activity theory within the wider landscape of practice theories.

While it is not possible within a single chapter to provide a thorough comparison of activity theory and other theories that might be used to study Strategy as Practice, useful comparisons of activity theory with structuration, situated action, distributed cognition, co-orientation, and other theories may be found in Blackler (1993, 1995; *et al.* 2000), Chaiklin *et al.* (1999), Groleau (2006), Jarzabkowski (2000) and Nardi (1996). However, some key comparative points may be made within this chapter. Many practice theories are based on a duality of action and structure that aims to go beyond earlier dualisms (e.g. Bourdieu 1990;

Giddens 1979, 1984; see also Ortner 1984). The premise of such theories is the reciprocity between action and structure, in which the two are mutually constitutive. However, other authors note that attempts at duality can tend towards either the structural (Bohman 1999) or the agentic (Barnes 2000) or, alternatively obscure interaction between the two such that analysis is difficult (Archer 1982). In part this is because of the recursiveness of reciprocal models of interaction between agency and structure, in which it is difficult to trace how social order evolves over time (Barley and Tolbert 1997; Jarzabkowski 2004, 2008). Activity theory is helpful because it provides a flatter ontology of action and structure than some existing practice theories (Blackler *et al.* 2000; Jarzabkowski 2005). While the subject is definitely an agent in activity theory, structure appears less permanent or reified in the notion of the collective, even as the collective does bring the longer duration concepts of culture and history that are important to understanding how practice is situated in context. In particular, the focus on activity provides a unit of analysis in which to observe neither agency nor structure but the way that such concepts continuously unfold and are re-accomplished in a stream of practical activity over time.

While other theories, such as actor-network theory (Latour 2005), also provide a flatter ontology that goes beyond action and structure, they do so by privileging non-human actors with an equal status to human actors. While actor-network theory represents one viable approach for studying how non-human artefacts are engaged in Strategy as Practice, activity theory is different. It conceptualizes non-human artefacts as mediators between actors but not as actors in their own right. They may have properties that mean they are not neutral but they lack the intentionality that is central to the concept of subject in activity theory. This is an important point of distinction in two theories that aim to better understand the interaction of people and 'things' without resorting to action and structure dualities. As Kaptelinin and Nardi (2006, p. 10) note: 'In acting with technology, people deliberately commit certain acts with certain technologies. Such a mild statement, seemingly devoid of theoretical freight, is in fact at odds with theories such as actor-network theory [...] Activity

theory distinguishes between people and things, allowing for a discussion of human intentionality.' While human intentionality does not underpin all theories of practice (see also, for example, Chia and Holt 2007; Chia and Mackay 2007), the language of strategy is, at its heart, a language of choice, agency and intentionality. In particular, if we wish to study how practitioners purposively construct themselves as strategic actors, activity theory has value in enabling the study of agency and intentionality in the use of artefacts.

Activity theory offers a range of theoretical concepts that are pertinent to the Strategy as Practice agenda. This chapter explains four main concepts, the subject, the collective, object-oriented activity and mediation. It integrates them into a framework that provides a set of resources in the continual endeavour to better explain strategy practice as it happens. While activity theory has been widely used in other fields, particularly education, social psychology and technology, it has had few applications in the strategy and organization field, with some exceptions noted in this chapter. This may be because its theoretical origins or some of its terminology, such as subject, object-oriented activity and mediation have not been clear to strategy and organization scholars. In providing some preliminary links between specific Strategy as Practice concepts and some core principles of activity theory, this chapter has endeavoured to make activity theory more accessible to Strategy as Practice scholars. Strategy as Practice aims to provide insights into how streams of strategic activity are socially constructed over time; by whom, with what intentions, drawing on which practices and with what implications. Activity theory provides a powerful resource for analysing these core Strategy as Practice questions.

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